

Kunwar Vijay Shah, Law and Legislative Affairs Minister Narottam Mishra, and Animal Husbandry and Fisheries Minister Ajay Bishnoi, all of whom have courted controversy in their first terms, drew the most protest. The chief minister managed to blunt some of the criticism by assigning the ministers to insignificant departments barring Uma Shankar Gupta, a second-time MLA, who walked away with the home portfolio. Defending their inclusion, Chouhan said, "Mere allegations are not sufficient to label someone as tainted."

When a mild-mannered Narendra Singh Tomar was appointed the state party chief, it seemed like an inspired choice, given his matching age and excellent equations with Chouhan. As the party goes through a wringing succession plan, the next party president might not be so benign, especially in case of a downslide in the party's performance in the ensuing panchayat and municipal elections. Chouhan's supporters point out that the new inductees give him leverage against ambitious political foes like Industry Minister Kailash Vijayvargiya, Health Minister Anoop Mishra and Panchayat and Rural Development Minister Gopal Bhargava. Despite the controversies associated with them, new ministers—Mishra, Bishnoi and Gupta—could provide the much-needed efficiency and competence.

If administrative matters were a consideration, the expansion couldn't have come any time soon. The Shivraj Government has been grappling with governance deficit. A successive second term in power for a chief minister is far more difficult than the first as rivals have already sorted out his strengths and weaknesses. Meanwhile, the mystery factor in voters' mindscape has already made way for concerns on more mundane issues. On July 17, the then Energy Minister Anoop Mishra promised the

GOVERNOR RAMESHWAR THAKUR ADMINISTERING THE OATH OF OFFICE TO NEWLY INDUCTED MINISTERS



Assembly that the state would be power surplus by 2012-13. Barely two months later, violent protests against long power cuts erupted like a bad rash across Madhya Pradesh. A violent mob stripped a junior engineer of the Western DISCOM on September 23 at a sub-station in Khargone district. Similar reports were received from other districts like Harda, Hoshangabad, Khandwa, Dewas, Jhabua, Dhar, Barwani, Betul, Sagar, Sehore and chief minister's former Lok Sabha constituency Vidisha. The Government has now decided to set aside a sum of Rs 300 crore to import coal at a higher cost to fire the state's dwindling thermal power output although power engineers debate whether the decade-old plants

can burn imported coal with high calorific value.

The reasons for desperation are not far to seek. The panchayat and municipal polls—whose outcome could well decide Shivraj's political future—would be held at a time when the Rabi crop season would be in full swing and the demand for power from the farm sector would peak. A spate of allegations of sloth and corruption in power utilities has undermined the BJP regime's credibility. The state's anti-corruption ombudsman, the Lokayukta, is investigating an alleged scam in short-term purchase of power without proper tendering process between 2005 and 2008. The DISCOMS bought short-term power from different private trading companies. Out of

“ The return of tainted ministers indicates that Shivraj Chouhan was in collusion with them. ”

DIGVIJAY SINGH, General Secretary, AICC